

3. The Strike

It took less than forty-eight hours for the official corporate narrative to solidify, smoothing over the violent fracture of the heavy ore-carrier like resin over a cracked bulkhead. On paper, the Samson-47 hadn't suffered a near-fatal cascade of human negligence, panicked sabotage, and system failure. Marek chuckled when he first saw his written testimony—it was an outright farce—but nevertheless, he learned his role for the hearings: the Samson-47 had survived an "unprecedented micro-meteorite impact event" through the heroic, highly coordinated efforts of its crew. The Sol media feeds ate it up. The rewards were handed down in a cold, sterile ceremony beneath the polished light panels of the inner-system transit hub. Leila—the heiress—received a prestigious high-civilian commendation for "unwavering composure and leadership during a spatial crisis". Alex, her golden-boy Navy boyfriend, was awarded a medal for military valor, his academy record now permanently gilded. Adam received a posthumous medal. Even the low-born crew got their standard bone to chew on. Marek was handed two official corporate honors: one for Valor, and another specifically citing "exceptional technical competence under extreme operational distress". The Captain knew the truth, of course. He had pieced together the missing seconds on Alternator 5, the fried quantum module in sub-deck G7, and the sudden, miraculous revival of Sequence A. He had tried to corner Marek multiple times, but Marek was always vigilant—and it would have been stupid for the Captain to chase a single man through a half-burned ship. Later, it became even more difficult on the deck before the transfer ships arrived, though the Captain still wanted to confront him face-to-face. But the opportunities were short, choked by corporate liaisons and administrative escorts. There were brief testimonies, but again, they barely saw each other; at the end of the day, corporate didn't trust Marek that much anyway. He simply read what they gave him instead of reciting it from memory. As far as Marek was concerned, it didn't make a difference; he was constantly watching his surroundings so he wouldn't run into the Captain. He legitimately feared the confrontation—the way a child fears an angry parent.

But eventually, the Captain caught him in the corridor. Short on time, he said he knew the truth and that he would eventually get to him. 'For disappointments like you, there is only disrespect and prison,' the Captain told him, 'and I'll get you eventually—I promise you that'. He added a few other scathing remarks, and Marek spend hours replaying what he had heard in the dark. Marek stood firm, nevertheless—he knew he couldn't be quietly recycled, not after being publicly decorated by corporate PR.

He didn't have proof, but everything indicated that the Captain was trying to protect the fleet from the presence of people of Marek's caliber. Sensing disaster, the Captain did the next best thing. In his final incident assessment, he noted that while Tech-3 Marek had shown technical resourcefulness, he was "demonstrating severe psychological strain, operational fatigue, and an inability to function within standard

crew hierarchies". He strongly recommended Marek be reassigned to solitary, low-priority utility duties. Specifically: the Cleaning Fleet. Marek hadn't fought it. He was already thinking about how to play it safe, but to him, it felt less like banishment and more like a reward. At the end of the day, he couldn't say for sure whether he was truly at fault or not, so maybe he shouldn't feel so bad about himself—after all, it was just a small vibration, nothing important... Regardless, working alone was also safer for him, so he wanted it. He wanted to be as far away from Sol royalty, corporate politics, and heavy crewed freighters as the void would allow. The Captain, however, was treated to a far more delicate corporate maneuver: forced retirement wrapped in administrative silk. The corporation tried to park him in an instructor's chair at a remote Navy academy—a glorified desk position once held by an old officer. The Captain pushed back, demanding a flight deck, and was demoted to a low-tier transport run—a quiet humiliation, though one that kept his corporate record intact. But shipboard rumors persisted that the man had struck a quiet, behind-the-scenes deal with Leila's family, and would be back in a command chair within a few years once the dust fully settled.

Closing on Rivet-32, Marek's thoughts trailed away. He had thought about this before, but now he was actively summarizing what he accomplished the first time. One minute he was brooding about lost opportunity—yes, he was doing some study and maintenance of the ship, but to summarize it all, he was mostly focusing on a black screen while developing his toy project in a shed. Staring at the display exactly like he would do on the asteroid. So that was it. Physically, he could be there, but he was tethered to his old ways. He told himself, "I need freedom, but when I get a taste of it, I just stare at a screen for most of the flight?". Even if he had developed something back then, what would he have done with the software? Sent it to the shipyard to get a medal? He had a few ideas, but all of them were pure fantasy, and he knew that. Maybe he was just like this. Space was not a place—it was a state of mind he was never destined to experience.

And this scathing feeling of shame—he was a coward. He just couldn't move when crisis hit and action was needed. At the end, he found this total numbness in his body, but it was practically held at gunpoint; for several entire minutes he could barely move. He knew it was old, plain terror of the situation. And his ridiculous decision—sheer stupidity of it was mind-blowing. He knew that he had this childish outburst of madness that he couldn't control, exacerbated by isolation, but the entire idea of forcing emergency maintenance? This was beyond anything he had ever experienced... shame...

"No, Marek, no, there was a difference."

Scarcely anybody has cutting-edge quantum computing at his desk and a completely free pass to data and ship telemetry. If they ever do have it, they are surely restricted, writing justifications for every use, and data is heavily curated. What he was dealing with was unprecedented, maybe even system-wide. Moreover, his software with all its flaws... he was getting there... ever so slowly. He remembered he was getting desperate, but until the very last moment there was gradual progression, barely noticeable, but when he looked back, he was moving forward until the very last unfortunate day. Unlike on the asteroid, he WAS tweaking an actual system, not just tapping buttons. On the ship, he was doing something epic, and he was close—he knew that.

There was something else about timing as well. When the ship disintegrated, they waited barely a few weeks for rescue, so a rescue mission was long underway by then. But because the ship disintegrated before arrival, they had to take all of them, if only to take their written testimonies. In another scenario, they would take Alex and Leila, and the crew would be floating—meaning that if there was legit structural damage, they would be dead by now. So his stupid action saved their lives, not doomed them. Permanent damage was there—no way it wasn't there, it was lurking, it was fatal—and his act of rebellion maybe by accident offered survival, not doom; besides, it gave him chills on its own.

That redemption was exactly the thought he tried to foster. Looking at approaching Rivet-32, he softened; he could look at those folks with his head held high after all. He was back, and he hadn't failed—at least not completely. He was still in that frame of mind when they started docking the asteroid.

On the surface everything stayed the same—this was, after all, good old Rivet-32—yet people quietly acknowledged him more than ever. A bit of gossip here, a bit there. During those first days, he felt genuinely proud of his new valor ribbon and his fresh assignment. Only Coval had tried to drag the real story out of him. Coval didn't buy the official micro-meteorite story for a second. Marek shared the trivia Coval already knew: "The time was not right for truth, not yet." But Coval suffered his own personal meltdown. He had used every bit of his dwindling political leverage to get assigned to a surface survey team on a near asteroid. Securing that assignment at his age was nearly impossible, but it backfired. Despite his suit's shielding, a freak radiation hit exposed him to triple the lethal dose. He barely survived, only to end up on 'red status'—stripped of his rank, duties, and access. During those days, Marek visited him. They played the board game Marek had always refused to learn. This time, Marek endured the effort, staring at the small tanks moving across the hexagonal

grid, getting outwitted and humiliated every single match. Still, he owed Coval.

His days passed smoothly enough, but the nights were agonizing.

He had done immense mental work to process the disaster, endlessly obsessing over every detail, but thoughts of Adam—foolish as he had been—haunted him, along with memories of the others and an endless internal dialogue. Darkness only brought silent arguments with the Captain, replayed on a loop. 'That hull was going to breach no matter what!' he'd snarl in his head. 'Your threats are empty. So I'm the biggest disappointment in your life? Maybe. But that's real life in the vacuum, not your polished academy simulations. You hid the true state of the ship. If you'd been honest, I wouldn't have pushed us past the limit. Blame yourself.' On other nights, his bitterness targeted Leila: 'Why did you even need us? A trained astronaut suffocates while you walk away fine? Weird, isn't it? Or maybe you just stole Adam's oxygen—maybe that's the only reason you dragged him along'. He went on like this every single evening, every single sleepless night, and it was agonizing. Yet he stayed away from alcohol and drugs. He knew from his early years that taking that path would seal his fate.

When the time came, Coval walked him to the port. Funny, they were chatting like in the old days. Back then, thought Marek, you were a role model for all of us. Do you remember? Everyone looked at you just to catch your attention, trying to follow in your footsteps. Rugged as you are today, and maybe not like we would imagine back then, and yet you walk me to the transport. As a child, I would be dizzy with happiness... it still means something, stupid as it sounds, he thought.

The corporate Cleaning Fleet was a dead-end assignment, but it possessed one crucial feature that Marek craved: absolute isolation. Unlike heavy ore-carriers or luxury transports, a sweeper was just a cramped engine block welded to a magnetic scoop array and a thruster ring. One ship, one operator. Across the sector, two thousand sweepers drifted in total isolation. Marek didn't know if they were observing him or not, so he decided to play it safe at first. "I will not give you a reason to just recycle me quietly," he vowed. With that mindset, he set about carrying out his duties. For the first six months, Marek forced himself into a rigid, robotic compliance. He told himself he was done overthinking. He wouldn't investigate anything. He would just read the basic instructions, clear orbital debris, hit his quota, and keep his head down. Yet he noticed things—he couldn't help himself. Your training is a farce, he thought. "I know a lot about ships by now, but without prior knowledge, it would be a coin toss whether I survived the first flight or not". But there was something even more depressing: corporate targets were brutally high, locked behind absurdly cautious procedures. Working strictly by the book, Marek barely scraped by at the very bottom of the

six-month performance listings.

Space is a scary place, he thought. Out here one is truly alone; it gets to you whether you want it to or not. Most of the day you see nothing, you do nothing; you just wait, executing some trajectory, some procedure... eventually, he knew this could break people. People did not come back even from routine space flight, even near asteroid orbit—found months later drifting in an undamaged vessel, cold and dead. He knew this even as a child, and he thought to himself, Am I immune to this? Whenever he reached a breaking point in his life, he ended up running away—broken, crawling, always finding some excuse. He was always reassuring himself: "This is only because this isn't real life. I am saving energy, observing. When it happens, I will be a completely different person, because in a nutshell, I am a completely different person. This is only a mask I am wearing to survive the day," he used to think. Now this is no longer theatre. I just need to get through this. I need to prove to myself that I can contain my insecurities—contain and crush them. But is that even possible?

Those guys from the freight ship flashed through his mind—young, optimistic, zero-stress people conditioned to win the game. And him? What kind of conditioning was he experiencing when he was just a free atom roaming in absolute nothingness, telling himself there would be better days? But he knew that eventually there would be a wall. There would be a situation he'd bounce off of—a moment where manufacturing the next excuse meant death.

Eventually, he stopped talking to ghosts, and his true nature reasserted itself. He felt safer as he began to understand what he could get away with—and when—before they caught on. "Now is the time," he thought. He just couldn't resist the blueprints for long. Despite the suffocating quotas, his cramped cockpit, and the looming threat of the ice mines, his restless mind dove into the sweeper's technical documentation, systematically replacing thoughts of people with system manuals and technical experimentation.

Technical documentation gave him refuge, safety, and clarity. "Darkness only exists when your mind is in the dark," he reasoned. Now he simply filled his head with an entire universe of devices and experiments. The dread vanished because there was simply no room left for it.

At forty-seven—or forty-eight, depending on the corporate calendar—he was finally where he had wanted to be his entire life: out in the deep black, completely untethered. Free from station claustrophobia and ore-carrier hierarchies, he treated the sweeper like a private laboratory. He burned thruster fuel he couldn't afford to

test manual drift vectors, mapped the decay of debris fields, and developed rogue methods for finding scrap. His theories didn't always work, but when a calculation hit within margin, he'd tap the display with a quiet grin: "That was clever... damn, that was clever."

There was something about learning a subject that was actually terrifying. Either you got it for "free" as a kid, or you had none of it at all. It is near impossible to hold new information in your head permanently. For him, it was simply about showing grit finally. "I spent years deferring it to a better time." He was recalling his library visit. Yes, he tried, but after a few days he simply rejected the effort, postponing it to the moment when a new burst of energy would keep him hooked for a while. There was next to no effect. Now it was truly different—he had a continuous streak—it gets under your skin, it's hard to stay motivated, and you hit a wall every single day—but he was determined to prove you don't have to be a prodigy to master something.

It had nothing to do with "brilliant minds" solving things in five seconds; that was just a fantasy people told themselves to justify giving up. Electronics was the toughest subject of all, yet somehow, he pushed through.

He jury-rigged a dual-antenna layout across the forward scoop array. Ditching the factory cable runs, he physically split the transmit and receive lines—mumbling "one wire here... one here..." through stripped copper in his teeth as he routed custom leads across his bunk. The extra decibels of crosstalk separation gave him full-duplex precision, turning the sweeper into a makeshift radar array.

He still had wild days full of dangerous ideas, placing a palm on the console to force a slow breath. "Calm down, Marek. Keep it on the leash." But slowly, he was grounding himself. He pushed the small engine throttle, listening to the hum of the hull and looking out toward the wider solar system.

In those isolated hours, surrounded by custom wiring and the vastness of space, Marek wasn't just a trash collector struggling to survive—he was the ruler of his own tiny domain, finding genuine joy in the void.

Then came the daydreams. He was here, and that was good, but it was only his first step. He thought more and more about the mysteries of the universe—planets, moons, other asteroids, actual stars. Staring at them was like dealing with the unvarnished language of the universe—one he was destined to eventually understand. It brought

back memories of being a child looking up at the sky, simply blown away by its mysterious vastness. He couldn't rationalize the visions yet, but he thought of himself as the one who held the key, and that gave him a profound sense of calm.

And he dreamed this way for two years, meeting quota, mastering equipment—and yet... eventually, he got unlucky.

In the current cycle, small failures had stacked up—a missed haul here, a bad drift calculation there.

It was a grounding, down-to-earth blow, because he had started to become one with his ship. The technical details, the math, the physics—it was all slowly starting to land. But there it was: this was a job, after all, and he was just making a living, nothing more than that. Fuck this, he thought. He did so well with the ship, yet he drowned in real life. He allowed himself to feel a little bit too secure, that's all.

He was sitting at a catastrophic sixty percent below quota, with barely two months left. The math was unforgiving: he was finished.

Corporate policy was ruthless—miss target numbers in a single cycle and you were summarily "retired," stripped of your berth and dumped back into whatever shithole you came from. Break equipment, and it was radiation ice-scraping for life.

In times like this, it unravelled slowly—but he knew the pattern. First came the creeping dread that he was missing something. Then, the sickening realization that he'd already made the fatal mistake, even if he couldn't pinpoint where. None of that mattered now. Fear took over, and old bad habits resurfaced. He was entering survival mode, and he knew it—quick, brutal, and ugly.

Scanning long-range arrays for a massive shortcut, Marek searched for a gap in the system—anything to bridge the void before corporate shut him down.

The trap was his own habit. Marek had always cut corners, bypassing safety delays on the scoops, ignoring standard trajectories, and pushing his thruster profiles to the redline. Because he operated at the absolute edge of system limits by default, he had no safe margins left to squeeze. There was nowhere left to overreach. "So all this time, I was just a gambler pretending to be a scientist," he thought to himself.

He started to notice his actual thought process getting shallow as it adapted to the crisis. He abandoned his study sessions and grew increasingly restless, harboring a rising panic as his composure evaporated. He had set ambitious goals, but for now—fuck them. He had to survive this crisis, and he would either make it or die trying. To that end, he simply shut down whole avenues of his mind; everything had to be sharp, brisk, and operational. Instead, he just began swinging between uncertainties on a daily basis, watching his judgment slip into a downward spiral.

Driven by pure desperation, Marek risked an unauthorized run to the extreme boundary of his sector. His long-range sensors had flagged a dense cluster of high-value metallic scrap—a lifeline big enough to pull him out of the hole.

As he approached the boundary, his heart sank.

Stephan—the rule-abiding, predictable sweeper—was already there, illegally harvesting the scrap hours ahead of him. Marek stared in furious disbelief. The one operator who never cut corners had just stolen his only chance. Quarreling was pointless; the haul was gone, and Marek was out of options.

Marek sat in his tiny cockpit, watching Stephan's sweeper pull away with the haul. Even twenty-hour shifts back in his own sector wouldn't make up the lost volume. He was cooked—he was going to miss the quota. "So this is how things end in this life? One minute you're fine, the next it's all over? Or maybe that's just how it is for people like me? No—I'll show you. You're not taking me down that easily. No way."

There was no avoiding it now. He had to double down on risk. The idea had been lingering in his mind for weeks, dangerous and alien, but he couldn't push it away any longer.

Buried in a technical footnote on the magnetic scoop array—a detail no desk-bound corporate engineer expected a sweeper to read—was a single specification: aperture calibrated to 60% rated structural tolerance.

Sixty percent. Corporate had deliberately locked away forty percent of the array's raw power to protect operators too stupid to manage their thermal loads.

Forty-eight years old, trapped in a cramped cockpit, and drowning at the bottom of the quota board, Marek stared at the monitor.

"Literally, I have no choice."

For three nights, Marek built stress models, shaving safety margins down to the redline. Widening the magnetic aperture would let him intake massive debris in a single pass. On paper, system tolerances held. In fact, he couldn't help but feel impressed by his own resourcefulness. All those days spent stewing over books and technical materials were starting to pay off handsomely. He felt that spark again. If I pull this off, it's more than just a success—it's an actual breakthrough. Maybe I needed this crisis to find my pinnacle? I have the hard data, and I'm going to act on it.

Out past his sector boundary, he targeted a massive, tumbling chunk of old hull scrap. Marek cranked the coils past corporate limits and drove into the approach. For a split second, the math triumphed—the expanded field flared a blinding purple, gripping the entire mass.

Then reality intervened. The boulder wasn't solid metal, but a decayed lattice of corroded weld seams. Pushed past its margins, the scoop didn't gather the rock; it detonated it.

The field collapsed, sending a violent kinetic shockwave straight up the collector arm. The ship bucked, throwing Marek sideways into the control bank as alarm sirens shrieked.

When the violence stopped and Marek wiped blood from his lip, the hold was empty. The scrap was gone, pulverized into a cloud of fist-sized shrapnel. He had modeled the stress on his own hull, but never the integrity of the target.

It took eight exhausting days to sweep up the mess his "genius" had created—eight days of bleeding time for a pathetic ten percent yield. He was battered, out of bounds, and nowhere near where he needed to be.

The only real upside: his ship's hardware held. His simulation wasn't wrong, but the clock was relentless. Even with that tiny fraction recovered, he was still fifty percent

short of quota with less than two months left.

It felt as if the world was actively penalizing him just for who he was—slapping him down every time he tried to outsmart the system.

"Unjust... completely unjust," he muttered, pounding his fist against the console. The simulation held, but somehow, the world always found a way to turn his efforts against him.

Few days later an official corporate notification flashed across his primary HUD. It was a mandatory, system-wide software update. The corporate memo attached to the file boasted a "significant 30% boost to sweeping efficiency through enhanced visual tracking and automated route optimization." There was, however, a small administrative caveat buried in the fine print: because of this "massive upgrade in efficiency," the baseline monthly quota for all sweepers was immediately increased by 10%.

The announcement hit like a punch to the chest. Marek thought his cynicism made him immune to corporate betrayal, but an intuitive knot formed in his gut—he knew real trouble was coming. He had simply begun to forget that Corporate even existed, and this brutal reminder pulled him right back to reality for good. Now, he wasn't just fighting against time—something bad was going to happen, and he knew it.

Marek installed the patch. The new software interface was slicker, brighter, and certainly made long-range debris tracking look cleaner on the monitor. But within three days, Marek—and every experienced operator in the sector—realized the update was an absolute farce. The software didn't change the physical reality of space. The sweepers were already operating at the absolute limit of their thruster heat caps. Most single-person operators had long since compensated for the old software's flaws through pure hands-on experience and dangerous corner-cutting. The update made the screen look pretty, but it did not increase the actual rate of debris retrieval by a single kilogram. Yet the 10% quota hike was very real. That "small detail" was actually a massive deal-breaker. A wave of bitter rage surged through the fleet. Over encrypted, sub-space operator channels—the untracked, low-frequency bands the sweepers used to talk shit about the brass—the discontent turned deafening. Operators who were already straining to meet their numbers were suddenly pushed

under the red line. Even the veteran sweepers who comfortably met their quotas were furious. "If they can pull a fake 10% raise out of their ass now," one operator broadcasted, "they'll do it again in two years. They're squeezing us until we snap." The sweeping job wasn't prestigious, but it was one of the few high-paying vacuum contracts available to low-born workers. For many, it was the only thing keeping their families off the station floor. This wasn't just an inconvenience; it was a career death sentence. The breaking point came forty-eight hours later. An operator in Sector 4, utterly panicked by his falling numbers, attempted a blind high-velocity sweep through an unstable asteroid cluster. His ship's primary drive exploded, tearing the hull apart. He survived the crash, but the corporate review board immediately ruled the incident a result of "gross operator negligence." Instead of receiving medical leave or a replacement hull, he was stripped of his contract and immediately reassigned to scraping ice on high-radiation comets. At least this was a rumor, and at this phase, that was more than enough.

The news hit the encrypted channels like a kinetic warhead. The anger shifted from quiet grievances to open revolt. Marek, who always felt detached from other people's petty problems, couldn't compose himself—he was triggered this time. "I played the game right, you motherfuckers, like everybody here!!" He was cursing, he was nervous. We need to do something, we need to... It can't be like that. Corporate can't just... Or can they, really? He recalled his days on the asteroid where he was simply shuffled left or right to make way for someone who "deserved better." Sure, he could blame this or that person, but behind it all was always the machine—a soulless mechanism squeezing them dry. And people complied; they allowed it.

The channels told a different story, though. It seemed every single person was feeling the same suffocating rage—venting their fury without holding back. He was not alone. These people were unlike those on the asteroid; a shared anger was ripping apart hearts and minds across the entire sector.

This was not the end. The encrypted channel was bloated with messages calling for action. More and more, a few people came forward proposing something unthinkable. Marek stared in disbelief: a strike was called.

Actually, he remembered a single instance of collective disobedience in his life—when they jumped out of school windows to run away from a classroom one day—how they were chased down and picked off. But that was back when he rebelled as a kid—or rather, THEY rebelled. It was just a prank back then, obviously. Looking at those furious teachers was hilarious. But later on, everyone knew better: they told you what

to do, and you execute. If you don't, they crush you and you're done. Once one person complies, then another, the corporation suddenly doesn't even have to try that hard—the hell is self-made. It was that way back then, and it would be that way here. They would be slaughtered, and one would be holding the knife for another, just as it always was. Yet they had the audacity to call a strike, and they had merit.

The logic was solid, and the sweepers knew they held genuine leverage. Corporate safety regulations strictly dictated that if orbital cleaning operations ceased in a transit sector, all commercial and military traffic through that corridor had to be halted within three days. Without daily sweeps, even tiny bolts and micro-paint flecks moving at twelve kilometers a second would shred the high-value hulls of incoming corporate freighters. "Without us, the sector freezes!" the strike organizers shouted over the comms. "We hold the line, and they have to bend!" The plan was simple: every operator who agreed to join the strike would switch their ship's distress transponder to a synchronized "Message of Protest" broadcast, effectively locking their sweeping array, parking their vessels in the debris fields, and refusing to log hours. They gave the fleet a six-hour window to declare their solidarity. Marek sat in his cramped cockpit, watching the comms board light up.

He hesitated. Resenting corporate authority in secret was easy; open mutiny was a death sentence. The corporation never let defiance slide, and survival instinct urged him to stay in the shadows.

His paranoid mind screamed that they'd all be crushed. Yet as he listened, an unfamiliar feeling bloomed in his chest: genuine hope, because on his own, he was just a guy who would miss his quota in this period, and that was it—he would be stripped and sent home, end of story, like it always was. But here, he was simply not alone. It felt exactly the same as in school back then—a childish prank elevated by grievances with Corporate into an act of defiance. And actually, he was the one who had grievances that he had fostered his whole life, who ditched his dreams in the first place. But look, even in this situation, it was just the same story again: angry about the guy sent to the ice, angry about the ten percent quota, angry that they were taking the only thing he had left. He was missing his quota regardless; demotion was coming, sending him back to his home asteroid empty-handed. No—he wouldn't yield his freedom so easily. No way.

This kept him rooted there, growing by the minute: a strange, intoxicating sense of unity, like a drug. He was a sweeper. These were his people. He wasn't just a bitter 48-year-old outcast hiding from his past—he was part of a front.

When the deadline hit, almost the entire fleet flipped their transponders. Thousands of sweepers went dark, locking their scoops in unison. Only a handful of cowards refused to join—including, who else, Stephan, the guy who had stolen Marek's scrap run. Marek felt a sting of hate immediately.

Among the strikers, a few fervent leaders quickly surfaced, flooding the channels with fiery speeches, demanding an immediate freeze on the 10% quota increase, immunity from corporate retaliation, and a mandatory "buffer month" to make up for lost time. There was also talk about the unfortunate fellow who went to the ice. Marek listened, his pulse racing, caught up in the wild, terrifying high of solidarity.

For the first four days, the corporation met the strike with complete silence. The excitement among the sweepers slowly began to curdle into anxious dread. Operators spent hours on the open comms, reassuring one another that the company was just bluffing, that the transit corridors were already choking on debris, and that the brass would break any minute. Marek's mood swung violently. One hour, he felt invincible, convinced they were making corporate history; the next, he was paralyzed by cold panic, picturing corporate security marshals ripping open his airlock. He secretly waited to see opposition against corporate rule his whole life, and now he was part of it. Yet they were simply brushed aside. Marek wondered how long until food rations collapsed, or whether corporate was already quietly picking operators off while transponders blinked uselessly in the dark. A few holdouts joined the blackout late, while others refused to budge. "Cowards," Marek muttered, though uncertainty was eating him alive. On the fifth day, the corporation finally responded. A formal, sector-wide administrative broadcast cut through every sweeper's HUD. The corporate voice was calm, sterile, and completely devoid of emotion: "All striking personnel are currently in violation of labor contracts. However, a grace period is now in effect. Any operator who deactivates their strike transponder and resumes cleaning operations within three hours will have the 10% quota increase temporarily waived for the current cycle. No disciplinary action will be recorded." The offer hit the fleet like ice water. You could feel the sudden, heavy silence across the sector as hundreds of operators began running the math—and Marek's mind instantly raced. If I back out now, the new software interface really is a tiny bit better. With the 10% hike waived, I can hit my quota. I can survive the half-year. I can keep my ship. He stared at the transponder toggle on his dash as agonizing minutes slipped away. In that cold panic, he envied guys like Stephan who had never joined—spared from carrying the weight of this choice.

He was constantly battling himself—one moment strangled by fear, yet a second later dismissing it as nonsense. They responded—they felt our rage! It was an obvious

hoax; they were trying to break our unity and then crush us individually. If we back down now—yes, it's safe, surely we avoid the ice—but it means retirement from any space or surface job regardless, made invisible to the system from now on. The writing was on the wall—he knew it, anybody knew it... or did they?

Meanwhile, the strike organizers rallied on the comms, furiously urging everyone to hold the line. "They are fearing us! If we set an example here, this will resonate throughout the Sol system, and they know it! They are acknowledging us!" Their demands grew even wilder—they now demanded hazard pay, full medical coverage for the guy sent to the ice, and complete immunity from future quota hikes. When the ultimatum expired, transponders across the sector stayed dark. Hardly anyone caved. A surge of hope hit Marek. Unity holds, he thought, caught up in the sudden, intoxicating conviction that he was on the right side of history.

The corporation waited another couple of days, letting the strikers stew in their own fear. Whispers of anxiety over food rations and families began to surface, but the fiery comms speeches kept the line from breaking. The company tried to infringe on the territory with patrols. Security cutters snatched a few isolated protestors on the fringe, but they couldn't force a real breach—and rumor had it one corporate patrol ship was sent limping back heavily damaged.

There is no way back, thought Marek, not after this. It's either us or them. Yet staying in individual ships doing next to nothing was exhausting. What was there to do besides stare at the comms console? Marek couldn't think straight, yet beneath the panic, an unfamiliar excitement burned—for the first time in his life, he felt part of something bigger. Then his mood would crash, crushed by the weight of the corporate machine. They could simply outwait them—because in the end, nobody beats corporate. Watching the few non-striking ships try to work as normal infuriated him. "If you won't join, just step aside, cowards!" But a handful of scabs couldn't change reality—the corridor was far too dangerous, and the strike had locked space down completely.

Those recurring voices on comm channels helped—those leaders, he thought—how does it work for them? Back on asteroid I was never noticed. Even now, I'm following like most others. And they rose out of nowhere. What makes me listen to them? Why am I waiting in anticipation for this or that guy? Why are his words worth more to me than my own thoughts? Could I ever be like that? Are they really such great people...? Maybe this resistance is just a way to feel important, to mean something. How is it truly for me? I remember that school prank so vividly—will that be my only reward

here regardless? Maybe I don't need to feel braver, bigger, or more powerful than I could ever be on my own. Yet this isn't school anymore, and this isn't a prank..." He was forty-eight years old, after all. He had seen things—many things.

The things he saw were not compelling scenes. Authority doesn't fuck around, typically. He pictured the worst: they would be shot dead or sent to the ice eventually, even if Corporate caved—they would come after them later, one by one. To stay safe, they would have to stay united forever—and deep down, Marek's solitary nature revolted. The solidarity was intoxicating, but the thought of being permanently tethered to a collective terrified him.

Then came the final corporate ultimatum: "Grace period closed. The 10% quota hike is permanent. Striking personnel face immediate reassignment to radiation facilities. Reserve cleaning units have been deployed to clear the corridor. You have two hours to surrender or be scrubbed". It wasn't a corporate negotiation; it was an execution order. Deploying a cleaning unit meant the company wasn't coming to bargain—they were coming to erase them. Just like that, the illusion evaporated. As the comms channel erupted in frantic, screaming speeches, Marek cut the feed. "The time for cheap charisma is over," he thought. Sickened by the noise, he leaned back in his harness, shivering uncontrollably in the sudden silence as he weighed his options. He had done his part; it was intoxicating, it was liberating. He knew he was doomed, but he hadn't met the quota anyway. If he flipped the transponder now, what would change? Surrender meant demotion and forced retirement, but at least he'd survive. His shaking hand hovered over the transponder switch—and his mind just froze, halting normal operations.

His eyes locked onto a conduit above the display. Emergency oxygen scrubber. Dual-membrane intake.

He stood up abruptly, his boots banging against the floorplates. "Primary coolant loop," he muttered, reaching out to touch the cold pipe. "Titanium-alloy jacket. Operates at four hundred kilopascals." He moved to the adjacent housing, fingers tracing the seam. "Main power relay. Manual override located portside..."

He kept moving, touching every valve, every conduit, reciting specs like a litany, using the cold technical facts to build a wall against the terror outside. He didn't look at the transponder. He didn't look at the clock. He just kept listing parts until his throat went dry and two hours bled into nothingness.

The period concluded. Within two hours, over sixty percent of the fleet had surrendered, furiously firing up their thrusters to start sweeping again to save themselves from the ice. Only a bitter, desperate twenty-five percent remained, and Marek with them.

What happened next was swift and ruthless. Corporate security ships flooded the sector, hunting down the remaining strikers, trapping their tiny vessels in the heavy debris fields, and arresting operators one by one.

Marek went numb. He was a rogue now—an outcast, a pirate. So what? A few hours and it's all over anyway.

"Nonsense... complete nonsense," he muttered.

He knew he was trapped. He couldn't go home—corporate security would flag his berth the second his sweeper docked. He couldn't run into open space. But he knew this sector better than any soul in the solar system. He would dodge. He would adapt.

Leaning over the console, Marek began analyzing thruster profiles, searching the debris fields for hideouts and mapping his next move.

Maybe it's not all over, he thought. He had heard rumors of places where you could just disappear and forge a new identity—shady asteroid hubs where you could actually run away, even from a corporation. Fuel was limited, of course, and he'd have to hide well, but a small ship isn't easy to capture. If he muted the engines, disengaged all equipment, set a cold trajectory, and pretended to be drifting garbage, he had a real fighting chance. In the corner of his mind, he thought: Is this the reason why I haven't yielded, why I didn't surrender—to force myself into a corner where I have to survive?

The plan seemed better and better by the minute, right up until he heard the metallic bips of a scanning sweep bouncing off his hull.

Fuck. They got me. The criminal underworld will have to wait, apparently.

He refused to switch his transponder off. Come and get me, you bastards. Only I know how to navigate this goddamn labyrinth. He sat in the dark cockpit, listening to his ragged breathing as security blips closed in.

I have nothing to lose. Chase me—chase me now, motherfuckers!

Then an insane thought crossed his mind. The corporate software update—mediocre as it was—flagged a cluster of massive, volatile dirt-boulders sitting right around the corner. If he overloaded the scoop array, he could detonate the cluster at point-blank range. No matter how slick you corporate boys think you are, we die together.

It was the ice mines or dying on his feet. Marek slammed the throttle wide open, redlining the thrusters as he drove straight into the intercept vector.

A heavy corporate patrol cutter drifted through the outer edge of the asteroid field, its long-range scanning array sweeping the spinning rocks. Inside the cutter's bridge, two security officers sat casually in front of their tracking monitors, sipping synthetic coffee.

"Got a hit on sector grid 4-7," the junior officer said, tapping his screen. "Tiny sweeper hiding in the shadow of a nickel-iron mass. Looks like another strike holdout."

The senior officer pulled up the target's registry file and blinked in surprise. "Wait... look at the service ID. That's Tech-3 Marek. The old station rat from the Samson-47 incident."

The junior officer raised an eyebrow. "The guy who got the Valor commendation? What's he been doing out here? Transponder's been dead silent the whole time."

The senior officer shrugged. "He never sticks to a checklist. Transponder must be failing—we're only getting weak gibberish. Threat level is zero, but keeping a signal live is mandatory. His numbers are garbage anyway—why does corporate even keep him around?"

The senior officer sighed, reaching for the short-range light-comms toggle. "He probably doesn't even know what's going on out here. Flash him with the optical laser. Tell him to fix his rig and get back to work before he gets himself recycled."

Locked in a state of suicidal focus, Marek barely noticed the transmission at first. Then a pulsing visual beam flashed against his forward viewport—optical code from the patrol cutter. On his HUD, the translated text blinked into view:

[YOUR TRANSPONDER IS BROKEN]

[YOU ARE BROADCASTING GIBBERISH]

[REPAIR IMMEDIATELY]

[STRIKE IS OVER - RESUME SWEEPING]

Marek sat in frozen silence, his chest heaving, his hand still clamped so hard on the throttle his knuckles were white. The patrol ship didn't arm weapons. It didn't intercept. It just drifted past like he was floating debris. The sudden dump of adrenaline left him violently nauseous. Was this a trick? He had wound himself up for a fatal final stand, yet the patrol cutter simply turned and drifted away. What the hell was going on?

Wait... this signal nonsense they were talking about—is it possible that my modification backfired?

Hands shaking uncontrollably, he unbuckled his harness, crawled into the rear maintenance hatch, and cracked open the primary transponder housing. Tracing the transmit cable, he found the damaged casing. Then it dawned on him.

Weeks ago, during that violent bump against the hull while attempting his illegal scoop maneuver, the transponder's primary TX coax cable hadn't severed. Instead, the force of the impact had popped the metal connector off its housing. The unit had been powered on the entire time, but instead of broadcasting into open space, the signal energy had been trapped inside the metal cavity, attenuating into an unreadable, ultra-weak mess of local noise.

It had never reached the fleet. It had never reached corporate receivers. He hadn't been participating in the strike at all.

For three weeks, while suffering agonies of fear, pride, and revolutionary fervor—convinced he was standing shoulder-to-shoulder with his sweeper brothers against the corporate machine—he had simply been a guy sitting in a dark, broken ship with a loose cable.

A wild, manic wave of emotion crashed over him. Marek broke into a harsh, breathless half-yell, half-laugh—a hysterical sound that echoed hollowly in his small cockpit. He hadn't defied the corporation. He hadn't risked the ice. He was just a pathetic, forty-eight-year-old idiot who didn't know how to inspect his own antenna connections.

When the outrage finally died down, a cold, hollow feeling of utter smallness took its place. He cried. He broke down, weeping in the quiet cabin until he was completely drained.

When the wave finally passed, a heavy numbness took over. Forcing himself back to reality, Marek reconnected the loose cable, re-engaged the transponder, and waited for corporate's next move. After a few hours, an automated summons flashed on his console, ordering him to report immediately to the central corporate mining asteroid.

Marek was ordered to dress in his official corporate dress uniform—a rigid, uncomfortable dress-parade tunic he hadn't worn since the honors ceremony after the Samson-47 disaster. Stepping off the shuttle at the high-tier corporate hub, he wasn't led to a security lockup or crew briefing room. Instead, armed guards escorted him down pristine, carpeted corridors—miles away from the grease and reek of the sweeper docks—stopping before a heavy, pressurized oak-veneer door. The guard opened the door, and Marek stepped inside. The chamber was massive, bathed in soft, warm light, overlooking the vast expanse of the asteroid ring through a floor-to-ceiling reinforced viewport. Standing near the glass, sipping a dark liquid from a crystal glass, was Leila.

She looked as impossibly radiant, sharp, and untouchable as she had the day he pulled the manual lever on the Samson-47. Marek stood frozen in his stiff dress tunic, his heart hammering against his ribs. For two years, in the quiet dark of his sweeper cockpit, he had built a mountain of bitter justifications in his head. He had convinced himself that she was a monster. He had blamed her for Adam's death—telling himself she had taken Adam with her into sub-deck G7 specifically to prey on him, to steal his

oxygen, to use him as a meat shield so she and her Navy boyfriend could live.

Then what was he doing here? Why was she here? Was it possible that back on the Samson, it wasn't about the oxygen at all? He felt a sudden sting of the very feelings he had tried so hard to suppress and contain, but he knew he was losing the fight. Why else would she call for him—exactly like she did back then? Deep down, he had always known....

Leila turned around. She didn't offer a warm smile. She didn't flash the blinding, magnetic charisma she used on the deck hands. She looked at Marek with cold, piercing disgust. "Shut up, Marek," she said quietly, before he could even open his mouth. "Don't speak. Just stand there and listen." Marek swallowed hard, pinned to the floor by her gaze. "I know exactly what you are," she said, her voice dropping into a razor-sharp whisper. "I know people like you. I've watched you. You sit in your dirty little corners, nursing your pathetic little grievances, convincing yourself that everyone higher than you on the corporate ladder is an evil villain, just so you can feel good about your own miserable, useless existence." She took a slow step toward him, her designer boots clicking sharply on the polished deck. "You think I murdered Adam, don't you? You've spent the last two years telling yourself that I took his oxygen, that I dragged him down into G7 just to survive. Alex spoke to the Captain after the rescue. He told me everything about his suspicions—how low you are, how desperate. The death of Adam isn't on my hands, Marek. It's on yours." Marek's breath hitched, but Leila cut him off with a sharp flick of her wrist. "Adam was clearing the maintenance path himself," she spat. "He was a proud crewman—a real spaceman, unlike a bitter station rat like you. When a structural support beam snapped in the corridor, Alex tried to push him out of the way. If Alex hadn't jumped, that beam would have sliced Adam in half. By the time we reached him, his suit seal was ruined, his ribs were crushed, and his oxygen tank was empty. He was already dead before we hit the G7 hatch. He admired me. He died trying to keep the sector clear. I didn't steal his oxygen, Marek—there was no oxygen to steal." She stopped inches from him, looking up into his pale, hollow face with pure contempt. "You despise us," she whispered. "You thought you were better than everyone on this hull because you read technical manuals and draw on whiteboards. But Alex told me what the Captain figured out... You fried a quantum module because you were playing pretend genius in your bunk. And then you shook the whole ship with Alternator 5 just to hide your own embarrassing mistake." Marek felt as if the room had completely lost pressure. His knees trembled beneath his parade trousers. "I've been watching your sweep numbers from the beginning," she continued coldly. "Every cycle, I thought, This is it. This half-year, he fails his quota, and we quietly recycle him. And yet you always dodged by a slim chance. Then I thought, just a ten percent hike and he's finished. Yet here you stand. You have no idea how much trouble you bring upon me." She turned her back on him, walking slowly back toward the viewport. "Alex told me about a lever," she said, her tone dripping with quiet cruelty. "You pulled that lever for my pod because you couldn't bear to watch me die. Now... get out of my sight. This

audience is over."

Marek walked out of the chamber in a silent, hollow daze, his mind completely numb under the weight of her words.

As he reached the administrative exit, a corporate liaison was waiting with an encrypted tablet. The man eyed Marek with a subtle, calculating curiosity.

"Technician Marek," the liaison said, offering a smooth, professional nod. "Congratulations."

Marek blinked, his voice a dry whisper. "Congratulations?"

"Your record during the recent labor dispute has been reviewed by executive management," the liaison explained, tapping the screen. "While over ninety percent of the fleet engaged in an unsanctioned work stoppage, your vessel remained operational throughout the entire crisis. Combined with your service record from Samson-47, management views your profile favorably. Receiving a direct audience with the Lady is an extraordinary exception."

The liaison handed him the tablet.

"Effective immediately, you are being reassigned out of single-person sweeper operations. You have been appointed Regional Overseer within the Fleet Management Division."

Marek stared numbly at the glowing authorization.

"You're done with manual sweeps," the liaison continued, his voice quiet and even. "Your new responsibility will be overseeing the remaining fleet in this sector—specifically, enforcing the mandatory efficiency quotas and managing compliance measures for operators returning from the strike."

The liaison leaned in slightly, lowering his tone to a discreet murmur.

"You will no longer be piloting—loyal people like us are meant for better things; we are just different from the rest," the liaison continued, his voice smooth. "Your new responsibility will be overseeing the remaining sweepers in this sector—specifically, managing the implementation of the Efficiency-10 motion and reprisal against those suckers who dared to participate in the strike."

The liaison leaned in slightly, lowering his voice into a conspiratorial whisper. "Unofficially? She barely ever talks to the low-born. You have to be different and loyal, unlike this scum..."

He shook Marek's hand and went on a rant, but Marek went numb, barely registering the words. Marek looked down at his trembling, gloved hands, wrapped in the pristine, ridiculous fabric of his corporate dress tunic. His mind was like a hive now: Promotion, Adam, Efficiency-10... Leila.

Finally, he whispered, "No, Leila... he was just a workhorse to you, and he died a workhorse for you..."